Visiting Dublin

Quick Notes

- Travel options to / from the airport to Phibsborough:
  - Dublin Bus: Routes 16 or 41 to Drumcondra, and walk up the canal
  - Aircoach: Route 700 or 700X to Drumcondra, and walk up the canal
  - Taxi
- If you're planning to use public transport a lot, probably worth getting a Leap Card (public travel card) from a machine at a DART or Luas station, or some newsagents also sell them
  - DART = Dublin Area Rapid Transport, the train service along the coast
  - Luas = tram network, and Irish word for speed
  - Buses are self-explanatory, but crucially they only accept cash or Leap Cards — no contactless debit / credit cards!
- Taxis can be booked using two apps:
  - Uber
  - FreeNow (which uses only registered taxis)
- Cars drive on the left-hand side :-)

Things to Do

History + Sights

- **Dublin Castle**: located right in the city centre, it gives a good sense of the history of the city — and you get to see the fancy state rooms. Worth getting one of their guided tours as you get more info and get taken into see a few extra parts of the castle.
  - *Self-guided: €8, Guided: €12 (can be booked online)*
  - *Mon-Sun, 9:45 - 17:45; tours 10:00 - 16:30*
  - *https://dublincastle.ie/*
- The **Chester Beatty Library** is also next door and is gorgeous — a huge amount of (dubiously sourced) Asian artefacts and heritage, and has a nice cafe too.
  - *Free entry*
  - *Mon-Sat, 9:45 - 17:30; Wednesdays til 20:00; Sun, 12:00 - 17:30; closed Mondays Nov-Feb*
  - *Tours: Wednesday 17:30, Saturday 14:00, Sunday at 15:00*
  - *https://chesterbeatty.ie/*
- **Trinity College**: worth going for a walk around the campus as it's very pretty. You could go to the Book of Kells exhibition, which is fine, but the real attraction of that exhibition is the Old Library which is gorgeous and iconic. (Expensive though for seeing a room!)
  - *Book of Kells from €19*
  - *Mon-Sun, 9:00 - 18:00*
  - *https://www.visittrinity.ie/*
- **Jeanie Johnston**: A replica from the Great Famine of a ship that took Irish people away from the island, primarily to Canada and America. Will remind you the Brits were (are?) bad.
  - *Entry: €15*
  - *Mon-Sun, 10:00 - 16:30*
  - *https://jeaniejohnston.ie/*
- **Kilmainham Gaol**: Located southwest outside the city centre, Ireland's leading freedom fighters were held here after their arrest. Great tour, but generally requires booking in advance.

- *Entry: €8*
- *10:30 – 17:15 (September – March); 10:30 – 17:45 (April – August)*
- *https://www.kilmainhamgaolmuseum.ie/*

- **Guinness Storehouse**: Any obvious tourist trap, but it's actually quite well done and good fun. Plus the Gravity Bar at the top gives an eagle eye view of Dublin, and entrance comes with a free pint. (There are better Guinnesses available in the city though!)
  - *Entry from €26*
  - *Mon-Thurs and Sun, 9:30 - 17:00; Fri-Sat, 9:30 - 18:00*
  - *https://www.guinness-storehouse.com*

Museums + Galleries

- **National Museum**: The National Museum has three campuses across Dublin. The Kildare st and Collins Barracks museums are both good if you're interested in their subject areas!
  - National Museum of Archaeology, on Kildare St (lots of old Celtic and Viking artefacts)
  - National Museum of Decorative Arts, Design and Military History, at Collins Barracks (features Panti's dress from her famous Abbey Theatre speech)
  - National Museum of Natural History (the Dead Zoo), on Merrion St (currently closed)
  - *Entry: free*
  - *Tues-Sat, 10:00 - 17:00; Sun-Mon, 13:00 - 17:00*
  - *https://www.museum.ie*
- **Epic Museum**: Covers Irish emigration and where Irish people have landed around the world, and their descendants. If you think you might have Irish heritage might be worth checking out. I haven't been to this one, but all reports are very good.
  - *Entry: €21 (includes return visit if needed); combo ticket with Jeanie Johnston €32*
    - *Reduced entry available for early mornings and late evenings (9:00, 17:30)*
  - *Mon-Sun, entry from 9:00 - 17:00*
  - *http://epicchq.com*

- **National Gallery**: A lovely modern building just across from Trinity, and free entrance so worth a look if you're interested in art, there's some nice pieces.
  - *Entry free, some exhibitions paid*
  - *Tues-Sat, 9:15 - 17:30; Thursday until 20:30; Sun-Mon: 11:00-17:30*
  - *https://www.nationalgallery.ie*
- **Irish Museum of Modern Art (IMMA)**: A very cool modern art museum, slightly outside the city centre. Exhibitions for 2H 2025:
  - *Entry: free*
  - *Tues + Thurs-Sat, 10:00 - 17:30; Weds, 11:30 - 17:30, Sun 12:00 - 17:30*
  - *https://imma.ie*

Politics

- **Leinster House / Houses of the Oireachtas**: The Irish Parliamentary buildings. A tour can be organised through my local representatives — let me know in advance if you want me to try to organise one.
- **Áras an Uachtaráin**: The President of Ireland's (currently Michael D Higgins, until the election in November) residency in the Phoenix Park. Tours are on Saturdays, tickets are free but have to be collected from the Park's visitor centre on the morning of the tour.
  - *Entry: free*
  - *Tours on Saturdays at 10:00, 11:15, 12:30, 13:45, 15:00*

Outdoors

- **Howth Cliff Walk**: A train ride away, but if the weather is good there is basically nowhere better to go than Howth to hike the cliffs and take in the beautiful scenery. Several routes are available of varying lengths, none are too difficult. Howth has plenty of fresh seafood too for refuelling after.
- **Phoenix Park**: Home to Áras an Uachtaráin (see above), the US Ambassador's Residency, and Dublin Zoo, the park is one of the largest enclosed parks in Europe. Lovely for a wander or cycle around, with plenty of places to see including an old munitions fort, and one of our only stately homes in Farmleigh.
- **Fairview to Bull Island**: A really great cycle lane runs along the coast from Fairview Park (which itself was the scene of a terrible murder that kicked Ireland's gay rights movement

into high gear), up to Bull Island beyond, but a great way of spending time by the coast. Good places to stop off for food in Clontarf on the way, or bring a picnic.

- **Croke Park**: The home of the Gaelic Athletic Association, Ireland's hurling, Gaelic football, and camogie head body, and also Europe's third largest stadium. If you've any interest in trying to see a match in-season we can check well in advance for tickets, but you can also do the Skyline Tour along the roof of the stadium to see inside as well as a view of Dublin's Northside and city centre.
  - Skyline: €24, Mon-Sun 10:30-14:30, https://crokepark.ie/skyline

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Queer

- **The George** - the oldest gay bar brings in the youngest crowd. Good for a drag show and a dance - pop music mostly, although the quality of tunes can be a little inconsistent. Friday and Saturday there's an entrance fee after 8pm, which I don't think is worth it.
  - Mondays: Win, Lose, or Drag, 9:00pm
  - Tuesdays: Dolly Grip and the Gripettes, 9:00pm
  - Wednesdays: Witchy Wednesdays with Veda, 9:30pm
  - Thursdays: Thirsty Thursdays with Davina, 9:00pm
  - Saturdays: Karaoke, 9:00pm
  - Sundays: Bingo, 8:00pm
- **Pantibar** - run by the Queen of Ireland Panti Bliss, Pantibar is on Capel St and is (probably) my fave bar. Looks great, good tunes, good vibes. A slightly older and Latino crowd.
- **Penny Lane** - a cocktail bar across the road from Pantibar, also owned by Panti. It's very swish, more chill than the other venues, and does a great cocktail.
- **Street 66**: a really nice and casual bar on weekdays that turns into a dancefloor at the weekends. Good gin bar. Nice as it has the most mixed crowd - more women in here than the others, mix of ages, also dogs frequently.
- **Mother**: The regular gay club every Saturday night in Lost Lane, just off Grafton St. Normally 2-3 DJs, specialising in club remixes of pop tunes, and has been running for over a decade, a really good night out.

Eating and Drinking

Phibsborough

So you've decided to stay in and have your ass handed to you in Mario Kart or Mario Party — good choice! There's plenty of good places to eat and drink around the apartment.

Breakfast and Brunch

- **Two Boys Brew**: the quintessential brunch spot in Phibsborough, it does really great food. Extremely popular so might need to queue, and not super cheap, but a really nice treat (and 2 min walk from the apartment).
- **Bang Bang**: a socialist and progressive-run café that specialises in baps and blahs (soft bread buns), it's a local favourite. Take-away, other than some school benches out the front.
- **3fe**: not going to get much food here, but this is an outlet from probably Ireland's most popular coffee producer. Just around the corner from the apartment.
- **Le Petit Breton**: crepes by actual French people, just down the canal in Drumcondra. Indulgent!

Bakeries

- **Russell Street**: Probably the best bakery in Dublin for your standard fare of sweet morning treats: almond croissants, pain au chocolat, pain suisse, pain au raisin, and cinnamon buns, along with incredible bread and good coffee. Generally a queue, especially on weekends!
- **Elliot's**: Based in the centre of Phibsborough, Elliot's is generally a little more sophisticated with their pastries changing by season. Also does great bread and sandwiches.
- **Filo**: Greek bakery that is across the road that does great savoury and sweet pastries, Greek sandwiches, incredible looking cakes, and good coffee.

Lunch and Dinner

- **Yeeros**: Greek gyros fast food that is pretty good — a favourite of mine! Sit-in or takeaway, veggie and gluten-free options.
- **Holi**: Relatively new Indian restaurant that's tasty! Sit-in or takeaway.
- **Hera**: Haven't been here yet but heard good things, run by the sons of Dunne & Crescenzi (see below), and next door to a cute pub called Juno. Sit-in.
- **The Back Page**: A sports bar that has a really nice vibe, and a big pizza counter out the back that does good thick-crust pizza. Their beer garden is lovely in the nice weather, and provided there isn't a crowd in to watch any sports, plenty of space to relax indoors too. Sit-in or takeaway. Veggie options.
- **Bunsen**: Probably the best burgers in the country, Bunsen has restaurants around the city but also a location in Phibsborough since the end of last year. Their menu fits on a business card: all they do is burgers and chips, so no veggie options here. Sit-in or takeaway.

- **Vice Pizza and Chicken Wings**: Unassuming from the outside but both the pizza and chicken wings from Vice are *so* good, properly indulgent food. Sit-in or takeaway, veggie options.
- **Eatyard**: A collection of food stalls in the back of the Bernard Shaw pub, offering a variety of food including dumplings and burgers. Sit-in or takeaway.

Eating and Drinking

Dublin City Centre

Breakfast and Brunch

- **Lovinspoon**: Greasy spoon, great for a full Irish
- **Lemon Jelly**: Unofficial gay cafe, does most breakfast options and decent pancakes
- **Brother Hubbard**: Queer-owned, and a really nice brunch spot: good food, great pastries. Moroccan-inspired so a little different to breakfast in other places too. Also good for lunch.

Lunch

- **Tang**: Really tasty middle-eastern inspired wraps
- **Nutbutter**: very healthy but tasty bowls — generally rice, veggies, and protein.
- **Third Space**: a cute community enterprise cafe in Smithfield, does great soup and sambos.

Dinner

- **Italian:**
  - **Sprezzatura** is a gorge little pasta spot. You're not going to get a huge meal but you'll get a tasty one. Generally requires booking.
  - **Aperitivo**, its new sister restaurant on Nassau St, is an Italian small bites place and is very good too. Small inside, so requires booking.
  - **Dunne & Crescenzi** does lovely pasta too, and all run by Italians so very authentic.
  - **Pi** does good pizza, sometimes a queue but normally not too long, and can get a drink close by while you wait.
  - **Dolce Sicily** does incredible pastries and cakes, along with lunch and dinner options too. Perfect for a dessert or a midday pit stop.
- **Asian / Asian Fusion**:
  - **Lucky Tortoise** in Temple Bar is great (but do not go for a drink in Temple Bar, absolute tourist trap).

  - **Yamamori** on George's St does good sushi and noodles.
  - **Ka-Shing** is a spot just off Grafton St which is frequented by Asian communities here and is really authentic
- **Capel St** is not a type of food but has lots of great places and is close to the gay bars:
  - **aobaba** for Vietnamese (they take cash only!!),
  - **Krewe** for American South,
  - **Brother Hubbard** (see above).
- **Cornucopia** is a fun veggie and vegan buffet location
- And you have to try **Murphy's Ice Cream** before you go — the Irish Brown Bread flavour is an icon, and they normally have gin flavours too.
- There are also plenty of more upmarket places to eat as well:
  - L'Gueleton (French-inspired)
  - Osteria Lucio (Italian)
  - Pichet (French-inspired)
  - Chequer Lane (Steak)
  - Soul (Seafood)
  - Featherblade (Steak)

Fast Food

- **Boojum**: If you're looking for quick and filling, Boojum is the winner of Dublin's slightly bizarre burrito wars from a couple of years ago and is pretty good fast food.
- **Di Fontaine's**: Perfect for a slice of pizza or two on a late-night stumble home
- **Umi**: Pretty good falafel places with a couple of locations around the city centre.